What Is Traceability?

Make the reasoning from user problem to product requirement visible.

Traceability is the ability to follow how a product decision connects to the problem it is meant to address and the outcome it is intended to create. It helps teams explain why a requirement exists, what it supports and how they might judge whether it works.

Why traceability matters

PRESERVE THE WHY

A requirement should not be an isolated instruction. Its rationale should connect to a user, problem, outcome or learning goal.

REVEAL GAPS

Missing links can show where features or requirements have no clear user rationale—or where an outcome has no supporting capability.

SUPPORT CHANGE

When an assumption, outcome or scope decision changes, traceability helps identify which downstream requirements and tests may need revision.

The central idea

Traceability is not paperwork for its own sake. It is a practical way to preserve product reasoning from the problem through implementation and evaluation, so the team can challenge scope and revise decisions responsibly.

Remember

A link is only as strong as its rationale. A chain of labels does not prove that the underlying problem or outcome is valid.

The traceability chain

MVPCompanion uses this chain to connect product intent to behavior and learning. Not every relationship is equally direct, but gaps should be visible.

1 · PROBLEM → USER
Who experiences the problem, and in what context? Keep the problem separate from the solution.

2 · USER → OUTCOME
What meaningful result should the user achieve, decide or experience?

3 · OUTCOME → CORE JOB
What is the user trying to accomplish to reach that outcome?

4 · CORE JOB → CAPABILITY → REQUIREMENT
What product support is needed, and what observable behavior must the product provide?

5 · REQUIREMENT → ACCEPTANCE CRITERION → METRIC
How will the behavior be checked, and what observation or metric informs whether the intended outcome or learning goal is being achieved?

Traceability test
For each requirement, ask: which user outcome or learning goal justifies this, and how will we check it?

A simple example

Illustrative example only. The links below show the reasoning to record, not validated claims about readers or book recommendations.

Example chain

PROBLEM	A reader finds it time-consuming to choose a suitable next book. (Hypothesis until supported.)
USER	A reader who wants a suitable next book and has limited time.
OUTCOME	Select a suitable next book with less effort.
CORE JOB	Choose a book that fits my interests and available time.
CAPABILITY	Help compare a small set of relevant options.
REQUIREMENT	When sufficient preference information is available, present a defined set of options with a brief rationale for each.
ACCEPTANCE	Given sufficient input, the system displays the agreed number of options and a rationale for each; insufficient input prompts the user for the next required detail.
METRIC / LEARNING	Observe whether users can choose an option and whether they judge the rationale useful; define measures and thresholds before evaluating.

Notice

If the problem or user assumption changes, review the outcome, capability, requirement and acceptance criteria linked to it.

Quick self-check: is the work traceable?

Use this checklist to find disconnected features, requirements without rationale or outcomes that cannot be evaluated.

Self-check

- [ ] Each important requirement points to a user outcome or explicit learning goal.
- [ ] The user and problem behind the outcome are identifiable.
- [ ] Core Jobs and capabilities explain how the product may support the outcome.
- [ ] Acceptance criteria describe observable behavior for the requirement.
- [ ] Metrics or observations relate to the outcome or learning question.
- [ ] Missing or weak links are marked as open questions.
- [ ] Dependencies and downstream effects of changed decisions are visible.
- [ ] Traceability is not mistaken for proof that the underlying assumptions are true.

Trace one requirement

Requirement or feature to trace:

Its user outcome / Core Job rationale:

How behavior or learning will be checked:

Takeaway

Traceability connects why a product exists to what it does and how the team learns whether it helps.